Introduction

In the past couple of decades, the regulation of student cell phone use in schools has become an increasingly prominent and contested social issue, with its influence even impacting educational policy. While the first state policies banning cell phone use were implemented as far back as the early 90s, many of these bans were repealed due to the tragedies of the early 20th century, such as the September 11 attacks, that highlighted the importance of phones in emergencies (Ballaro, 2024). Today, the advanced technology of mobile phones and the unparalleled capabilities of the online world have led to new concerns about navigating the role of technology and social media in learning environments and novel circumstances such as online school during the pandemic. Subsequently, many states have brought back and enforced laws banning or restricting student cell phone use in secondary education schools during instruction hours (Yancey-Bragg, 2026). These rapid changes emphasize how quickly social norms and institutional expectations can change. As of January 2026, more than half of the states in the United States have passed and applied policies on phone use in school during instructional hours (Phone-Free Schools State Report Card).

The topic is particularly important given that phones play an essential role in people's everyday lives. For many students, cell phones serve not only as tools for communication but also as resources for academic work, safety, social connection, and organization. As a result, such restrictions have been met with strong opinions voiced by students, parents, and teachers. Although educational policies on cell phone use are typically implemented with intended benefits, such as reducing distractions, increasing attention spans, and supporting students' mental health, they have also been criticized as overly controlling and out of touch with the needs of modern students (Carrillo, 2025).

On a larger scale, this issue is especially interesting as the developments and changes in state legislation regarding student cell phone use in schools illustrate the extent to which government and educational institutions can regulate personal technology. These changes raise even broader questions about the role of institutional regulations in shaping the future of educational environments. Furthermore, the controversy surrounding these policies underscores the degree to which society relies on mobile technology to go on with daily life.

Influencing attitudes towards student cell phone restrictions would be desirable because the perspectives held by students, educators, legislators, and parents are often strongly held, grounded in idiosyncratic, personal experience, and supported by legitimate reasoning. As a result, attitudes toward this issue are likely to be resistant to change and can serve multiple functions for individuals and social groups. Therefore, it would be meaningful to study how and what can form and change such deeply entrenched beliefs, perceptions, and sentiments, if at all.

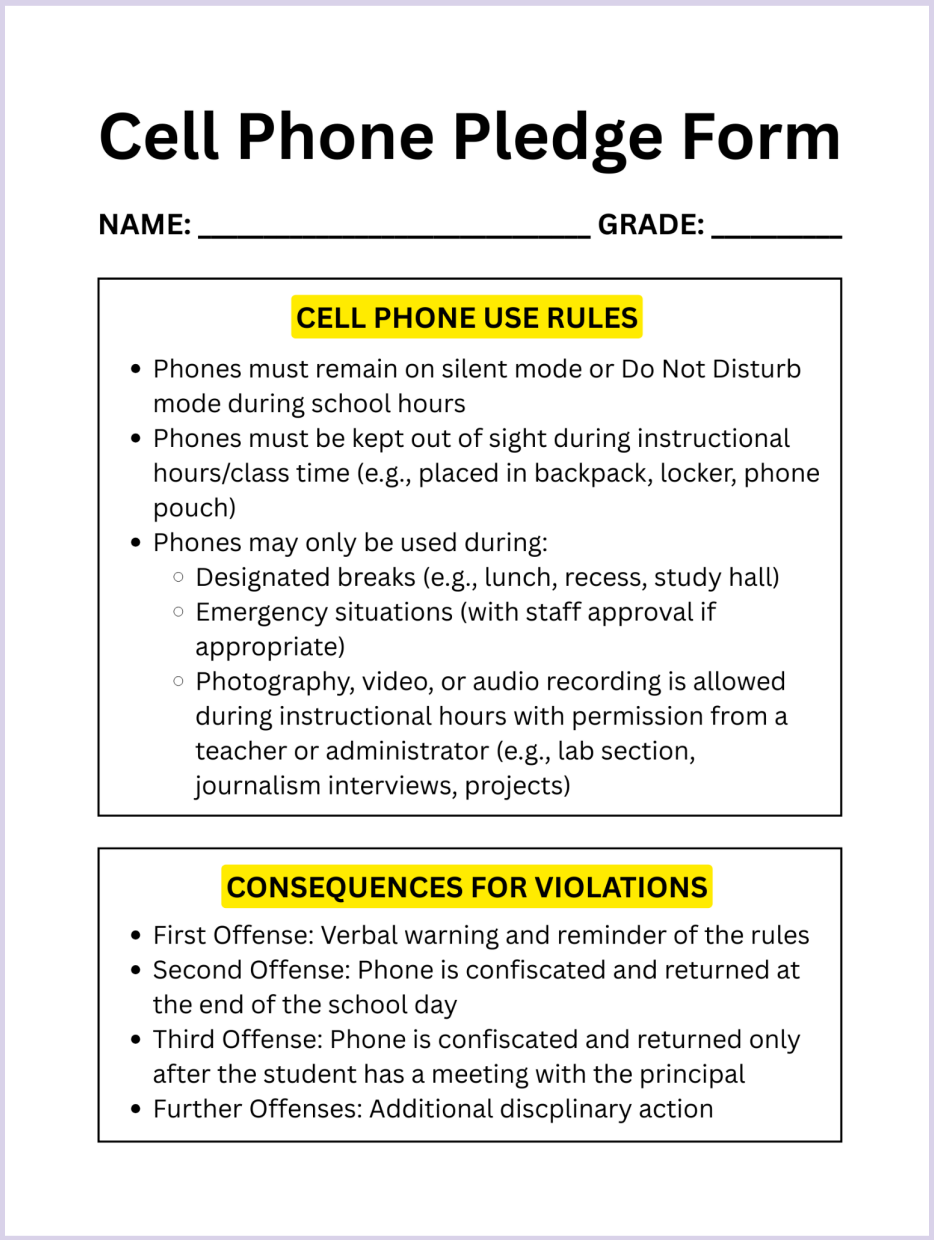
Survey Results

The survey responses collected in Part 1 indicate that nearly all survey respondents agreed that cell phones can serve as significant distractions and have the potential to disrupt students' focus and engagement during class. All respondents of the survey were college students between the ages of 19 and 22. Several students explicitly acknowledged the negative academic consequences of in-class phone use. For example, one student responded that "banning [phones] might improve focus," while another commented that "phones are mainly used for distraction purposes."

Several responses also emphasized the role of personal responsibility, with one participant claiming that "it is a student's responsibility to use their phone appropriately and not

as a tool for distraction." Overall, it was found that people generally hold a negative attitude towards cell phone usage in schools.

Persuasion Campaign & Attitude Change



Cell Phone Pledge Form

NAME: _____ GRADE: _____

CELL PHONE USE RULES

- Phones must remain on silent mode or Do Not Disturb mode during school hours
- Phones must be kept out of sight during instructional hours/class time (e.g., placed in backpack, locker, phone pouch)
- Phones may only be used during:
  - Designated breaks (e.g., lunch, recess, study hall)
  - Emergency situations (with staff approval if appropriate)
  - Photography, video, or audio recording is allowed during instructional hours with permission from a teacher or administrator (e.g., lab section, journalism interviews, projects)

CONSEQUENCES FOR VIOLATIONS

- First Offense: Verbal warning and reminder of the rules
- Second Offense: Phone is confiscated and returned at the end of the school day
- Third Offense: Phone is confiscated and returned only after the student has a meeting with the principal
- Further Offenses: Additional discplinary action

My persuasion campaign consists of a school-wide email reminding high school students of a pledge they signed at the beginning of the academic year, committing to follow the school's 'Cell Phone Use Rules." The pledge specifies when cell phone use is permitted during

instruction hours and outlines the consequences for violating these guidelines. By reminding students of this prior commitment, the campaign highlights a potential discrepancy between their stated intentions and their current behavior.

This persuasion campaign strategy draws on cognitive dissonance theory. Students' current phone use during instructional time may conflict not only with the pledge they voluntarily signed but also with their previously expressed negative attitudes toward in-class phone use. In the survey conducted for Part 1, respondents acknowledged that cell phones are distracting and can undermine classroom focus. Additionally, many students view themselves as responsible and trustworthy individuals who are capable of regulating their own behavior. When their actual behavior, such as checking or using phones during instructional hours, conflicts with both their self-concept and their prior commitment, this inconsistency creates psychological discomfort, or dissonance.

To reduce and resolve this cognitive dissonance, students are likely to align their behavior with their attitudes and commitments. In this case, such changes would involve reducing phone use during instructional time and recommitting to the standards outlined in the pledge. Over time, engaging in attitude-consistent behavior may further strengthen and reinforce students' negative attitudes towards in-class phone use and potentially increase their support for phone regulation policies within schools.

I expect this dissonance-based approach to be effective, based on research by Kantola et al. (1984), who examined household energy conservation. In their study, households that were reminded of their previously expressed commitment to conserving energy and informed that their energy use was high (the dissonance-salient condition) reduced their energy consumption significantly more than households that merely received an informational tips pamphlet or a

neutral thank-you message. The research found that households in the hypocrisy or dissonance-salient group reduced their energy consumption significantly more than those in the informational tips group or control group, indicating that creating psychological inconsistency is more impactful than simply giving people helpful information on how to fix their behavior. Consistent with Kantola et al.'s (1984) results, my persuasive campaign does not rely solely on instructing students how to appropriately regulate their phone use in school during instructional hours. Instead, it strategically induces cognitive dissonance by reminding students of their prior commitment, thereby motivating them to align their behavior with their stated values and agreements.

Another component of my persuasion campaign involves assigning students the task of crafting a Public Service Announcement (PSA) or writing a brief persuasive paragraph explaining why unregulated cell phone usage in schools can be distracting and harmful to learning. The survey findings from Part 1 indicate that many student respondents already support the belief that in-class phone use undermines focus and academic engagement. By asking students to actively generate arguments supporting this position, the campaign encourages deeper cognitive processing of attitudes they already hold.

This exercise may also increase the salience of discrepancies between students' stated beliefs and their own behavior. Reflecting on instances in which they used their phones in class for non-academic purposes highlights the inconsistency between their expressed views and their actions. According to Festinger's cognitive dissonance theory (1957), such inconsistencies create psychological discomfort, motivating individuals to align their future behavior with their articulated attitudes to restore consistency through rationalization or external justification.

Moreover, the effort involved in constructing a persuasive message may further strengthen this effect. When students invest time and cognitive energy into advocating against classroom phone distractions, they may feel compelled to justify that effort by behaving consistently with the position they defended. Finally, reflecting on their past behavior may evoke moral dissonance by drawing attention to a gap between their actions and their self-perception as responsible and conscientious students. Together, these mechanisms increase the likelihood of both behavioral change and strengthen negative attitudes toward unregulated, inappropriate phone use in school. Heightened attitude strength reflects increased intensity of students' beliefs and feelings towards phone use in schools, manifested in attitude accessibility, certainty, and attitude extremity. The PSA assignment repeatedly activates negative attitudes toward phone distraction, making those attitudes more accessible and more likely to guide in-class behavior.

Overcoming Resistance

The persuasion campaign can overcome resistance through the use of narrative camouflage and narrative transportation. Forceful and heavy-handed persuasion strategies may provoke strong reactance among students, as they could perceive strict messages from teachers and administrators as threats to their personal freedom and autonomy. When individuals feel that their freedom is being restricted, they often respond by resisting the message or defending their existing behavior.

To reduce such resistance, this campaign employs a more subtle method of narrative camouflage by assigning students to create a PSA or write a brief reflection about the consequences of unregulated phone use in schools. This approach embeds the persuasive message within an immersive narrative context rather than presenting it as an authoritative instruction. Through narrative camouflage, the message about the harms of inappropriate

classroom phone use is framed within an engaging story-like task, making it less likely to be perceived as coercive.

Narrative transportation suggests that individuals who become absorbed in a compelling narrative are less likely to engage in counterarguing and more likely to adopt the beliefs or attitudes conveyed by the story. When people are "transported" into a narrative, they often experience vivid imagery and emotional engagement that increases their openness to persuasion. By creating their own PSAs or reflections, students may become immersed in the narrative they construct, reducing the likelihood that they will critically challenge the message or question the campaign's validity. This approach can also reduce inertia, one of the four faces of resistance, by actively engaging students in the persuasive process rather than relying on passive exposure to the message, thereby decreasing the likelihood that students will disengage from the campaign.

While narrative camouflage and transportation primarily operate through the peripheral route by lowering resistance and reducing counterarguing, the campaign also incorporates elements that encourage central-route processing. According to the Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty et al., 2012), persuasion through the central route occurs when individuals have both the motivation and the ability to carefully process strong persuasive arguments. In this case, the educational setting provides an environment conducive to concentration, and students possess the cognitive ability necessary to engage with the persuasion task.

Narrative camouflage and transportation also serve as safeguards when students are not sufficiently motivated to engage deeply with the campaign's arguments. In such situations, these narrative elements provide positive peripheral cues that can bias elaboration in a favorable direction, increasing the likelihood that students will generate supportive thoughts about regulating cell phone use in schools.

Conclusion

Overall, this persuasion campaign combines dissonance-based strategies with narrative engagement to promote both attitude and behavior change regarding cell phone use during instructional time. By reminding students of their prior commitment to the school's cell phone pledge and encouraging them to actively generate persuasive messages about the harms of unregulated phone use, the campaign highlights inconsistencies between students' beliefs, self-concepts, and behaviors. According to cognitive dissonance theory, these inconsistencies create psychological discomfort that motivates individuals to align their actions with their stated attitudes and commitments. At the same time, the use of narrative camouflage and transportation helps reduce resistance and reactance, increasing students' openness to persuasion.

Together, these strategies encourage students to reflect on their phone use, strengthen their negative attitudes toward classroom distractions, and ultimately reduce inappropriate phone use during instructional hours. By integrating both central and peripheral routes of persuasion, my campaign aims to produce more durable changes in students' attitudes and behaviors, while also increasing support for structured phone regulation within schools.

Works Cited

Ballaro, B. (2024). *Cell Phones in School: Overview | Research Starters | EBSCO Research*. EBSCO. https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/communication-and-mass-media/cell-phones-school-overview

Carrillo, S. (2025, September 1). More students head back to class without one crucial thing: their phones. NPR. https://www.npr.org/2025/09/01/nx-s1-5495531/more-states-now-ban-cell-phones-in-schools

Festinger, Leon. *A Theory of Cognitive Dissonance*. *Stanford University Press eBooks*, 1957. https://doi.org/10.1515/9781503620766.

Kantola, S. J., G. J. Syme, and N. A. Campbell. "Cognitive Dissonance and Energy Conservation." *Journal of Applied Psychology* 69, no. 3 (August 1, 1984): 416–21. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.69.3.416.

Petty, Richard E., and Pablo Briñol. "The Elaboration Likelihood Model." In Hand of Theories of Social Psychology, 224–45, 2012. https://doi.org/10.4135/9781446249215.n12.

Phone-Free schools State report card. (n.d.). https://www.phonefreeschoolsreport.org/#overview

Yancey-Bragg, N. (2026, January 20). States enact strict bans on phones in school. See how your state ranks. *USA TODAY*. https://www.usatoday.com/story/news/nation/2026/01/20/cellphone-ban-school-states/88263289007/